Bouillon/stock cubes and powdered seasoning blends (dry rubs, gravy/seasoning packets): HMTc Standard

Karen Pendergrass · 0000-0002-2348-7259 · Heavy Metal Tested & Certified, Institute of Contaminant Standards

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CORRESPONDENCE

Corrections are logged publicly on the article page, each with its date, the affected value, and the source that resolved it.

KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08.

Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified standard for Bouillon/stock cubes and powdered seasoning blends (dry rubs, gravy/seasoning packets) (Herbs, Spices, Seasonings and Salt), stated as sold. Each analyte carries the strictest applicable government maximum level in the product's native basis, with a disclosed read-across or a mandatory control where no government regulates the exact product.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit default; explicit-id lookup; legislated product-form splits preserved; dried-spice basis discipline)

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as sold basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS
Lead (Pb)	1,000	government maximum level
Cadmium (Cd)	1,000	sovereign maximum level
Total arsenic (tAs)	1,000	sovereign maximum level

Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	100	government maximum level
Mercury, total (tHg)	50	sovereign maximum level
Methylmercury (MeHg)	n/m	not material in this matrix
Nickel (Ni)	—	—
Tin (Sn)	n/m	not material in this matrix
Aluminium (Al)	n/m	not material in this matrix
Total chromium (Cr)	—	—
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	—	—

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG / DETERMINATION
Lead (Pb)	1,000	government maximum level
Cadmium (Cd)	1,000	government maximum level
Total arsenic (tAs)	1,000	government maximum level
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	100	government maximum level
Mercury, total (tHg)	50	government maximum level
Methylmercury (MeHg)	n/m	Methylmercury is the organomercury speciation of mercury and is arithmetically bounded by total mercury (MeHg <= tHg); a dry seasoning blend of spices, salt and starch has no methylmercury formation pathway, and it is bounded by the read-across total-mercury limit.
Nickel (Ni)	—	—
Tin (Sn)	n/m	No tin source in a foil/pouched dry seasoning blend or a stock cube; tin is a tinplate-can migration pathway only.

Aluminium (Al)	n/m	A seasoning blend is compositionally spices plus salt; its aluminium is the natural-accumulator spice background plus permitted anti-caking additive, managed by intake against the EFSA/JECFA TWI and by additive law, not by a per-food contaminant maximum level. Consistent with the spices/Al and salt/Al determinations.
Total chromium (Cr)	—	—
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	—	—

4 | Cite this standard

Pendergrass, K. (2026). *Bouillon/stock cubes and powdered seasoning blends (dry rubs, gravy/seasoning packets): HMTc standard*. Institute of Contaminant Standards.

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STATUS AND LICENCE

A normative certification standard, editorially reviewed and version-controlled in-house; every value traces to a named sovereign maximum level, disclosed in the derivation. © 2026 Institute of Contaminant Standards / Heavy Metal Certified. All rights reserved.

COMPETING INTERESTS

This briefing is published by the Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) program, operated by the Institute of Contaminant Standards. Its statements about government regulations, toxicology, and occurrence are sourced to the cited primary and expert-body records and to the independently maintained Heavy Metal Index; the program's own certification thresholds are not used as evidence for any factual claim made here.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this reference draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the briefing page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/bouillon-seasoning-blends. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08. The full dated record is maintained at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/bouillon-seasoning-blends.